

delighted—it was like she had brand new toys. I was delighted, too: I didn't have to buy a thing. Bonus: you'll cut down on clutter and have fewer toys to trip on in the middle of the night.

4. **Minimize the meat.** The most expensive items on any grocery list are the meat products—beef, chicken, pork, fish. But you don't have to have meat at every meal. Eat like a vegetarian every once in a while, subbing in potatoes, mushrooms, eggplants and other vegetables instead of pricey meat. Bonus: your arteries will thank you.
5. **Use the barter system.** We have a family friend who's a piano teacher and a single mom. Her kids are grown now, but when they were school-aged, she always managed to get her kids into private schools. How'd she afford it? She offered her services in exchange for tuition. She gave piano lessons and taught music classes. The barter system is still alive and well—you just have to trade something that other people want. Bonus: you'll be more involved in your community.
6. **Make their clothes last.** Kids don't need designer clothes. There is nothing more senseless than buying couture onesies for your one-year-old. Frankly, I don't think children need designer clothes at any age. Kids outgrow stuff quickly, so your goal should be to make their basic wardrobes last as long as possible. When they outgrow their blue jeans, cut them off. Voilà: now they've got jean cutoffs for the summer. Don't fall into the trap of keeping up with the Joneses when it comes to kids' wardrobes. Believe me, it's better to save the extra money and use it for something of real, lasting value—such as your children's education. Older kids can pass clothes down to their younger siblings, even across genders. Most shirts, sweaters, and even some pants are unisex. Bonus: maybe your kids will start a new trend.